

Kulu the Turtle

Kulu the turtle sat beneath the tree, quietly chewing on grass, but his mind was wandering far away. On a branch above him, two cuckoos sit side by side, singing together. There was a strange sweetness in their melody, as if they were singing only for each other.

Kulu slowly lifted his neck and wondered,
“Will there ever be someone for me too... someone who would sit with me just like this and share time?”

Nearby, many turtles basked lazily in the warm sunlight.
No one called out to anyone, and no one waited for anyone else.

Kulu had tried many times to go sit beside others, gently tapping his head against theirs in a gesture of friendship.

But every time, the other turtle simply shifted a little aside... as if saying, *“Leave me alone.”*

Then came the mating season.

Suddenly, the forest was full of restlessness. Male turtles began trailing behind the females.

But Kulu remained where he was apart, distant.

He had seen it happen every year:

after mating, the males would leave the females right there and wander off in search of another, and the females too would go far away, find a safe spot, dig the soil, and leave their eggs behind
as if they felt no attachment to them at all.

Kulu thought to himself,

“If togetherness lasts only for a moment, what meaning does it hold?”

Once, Kulu too had followed a female and mated with her.

But soon after, he saw her moving away.

Kulu tried hard to stop her, but
Who can stop nature?

He grew deeply sad and withdrew into his shell for days, tucking his legs and arms inside.

His shell grew even harder.

During that time, heavy rains began.

The whole forest was flooded.

After many days, Kulu emerged from his shell.

He saw no one around; perhaps the heavy rain had driven everyone to distant places.

Kulu climbed onto a stone ledge and basked quietly in the sun.

From there, he spotted a large pond.

He walked to the pond and noticed another turtle looking back at him from the water.

Whenever he leaned forward, the other turtle wavered strangely, its shape breaking apart in the ripples.

So Kulu decided not to touch the water.

Kulu lifted one foot, and the turtle opposite lifted one too.

He moved his neck, and the other copied him.

This delighted Kulu.

He gathered some leaves in his mouth and approached the water again.

He saw the other turtle with leaves in its mouth too.

When Kulu began eating, the other began eating as well.

Kulu felt he had finally found someone,
someone who wanted to stay with him, who wanted to share leaves with him.

Kulu was happy now.

He no longer grew sad seeing other creatures with their companions; instead, it made him smile, for he knew he had a companion too.

Day after day, he spent all his time by the pond.
And the days passed gently, filled with a quiet joy.

Then one day, heavy rains returned.
Kulu grew anxious for his pond-side companion.
Using all his strength, he rushed toward the pond.

What he saw made his heart tremble
his companion was breaking apart under the falling raindrops, the water
darkening, the image fading.
His friend was disappearing.

Kulu panicked.
He wanted to dive in and save him,
but he knew that whenever he touched the water, the other turtle began to vanish.

He tried to hold himself back.
But the rain grew harsher, the water muddier.
Kulu could not stop himself anymore
and he jumped into the pond.

There was no one there.

The one he had eaten with, spoken to,
the one who mirrored his movements, copied his gestures
all of it...

It had all been...

The light above him dimmed in his eyes...
and slowly, gently, dissolved into darkness.